

End Paper

Gardens of the Homeless



"JIMMY'S GARDEN," COPYRIGHT © 1993 MARGARET MORTON

HISTORICAL RECORDS have always fostered the gardens of the wealthy and powerful, who can preserve or document their gardens. Long identified with affluence and ease, these gardens provide a place for leisurely enjoyment, private retreat, contemplation, and social interchange. The variety of these activities, in fact, even serves as a clue to the use of the garden as a space for regeneration and life. These are gardens that have been maintained over time, gardens for which drawings and plans can be found. They are also the gardens that get recorded in literature, music, painting, and photography. Wealth allows for both the making of the garden by a good artist, thus ensuring its survival on aesthetic grounds, and its documentation in other forms of art.

Gardens other than those of the wealthy have rarely left a trace. But there are some exceptions—those few gardens that have floated up through history in the line of a poem, the words of a song, or the fragments of a memoir: a small garden outside a medieval city wall; a monastery garden for healing those without any means; a garden leading to a

Japanese teahouse, not more than a narrow corridor with a single tree and a few stones, whose very intent was to shun the use of anything costly. It is to these modest examples that we hope to add by capturing the image and material of gardens unique to our own time.

In *The Garden as Earthly Paradise*, A. Bartlett Giamatti presents the garden as a creation of hope and fulfillment; paradise is, in fact, the hidden paradigm to which garden making implicitly aspires. Giamatti suggests that after the Renaissance, the garden as an ideal nearly disappears in literature. While these literary observations may be true, nevertheless, in itself the garden at all times has had an immanent power, waiting to be released by an act of creative will. This power remains constant but mutable, awaiting new interpretations.

It is this power rather than of paradise that the gardens of the homeless speak. And they do so while connecting themselves, albeit tenuously, to Giamatti's definition. These gardens are not a part of the historical tradition in which the vestiges of paradise are embedded; they do not reflect the

nineteenth-century picturesque model; they are not part of the family of gardens illustrated in popular magazines. Moreover, no lush, paradisiacal materials are available for their making.

Constructed out of scarcity by persons whose basic needs—food, work, and shelter—are not met, they embody a sense of the precariousness and fragility of nature. Yet we cannot say that they lack a link with the mythic past of the garden or with its power. Few better examples of hope and the wish for fulfillment could be found.

The text above is by Diana Balmori, critic in landscape at Yale University School of Architecture and lecturer at the university's School of Forestry, and Margaret Morton, photographer and associate professor of art at the Cooper Union School of Art.

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